

offered to support the last-ditch Crittenden Compromise, which unsuccessfully tried to curtail the creation of new slave states.

The newly formed Confederacy chose Davis as president, in the hope that his somewhat moderate prewar record might attract the support of the upper South.

Davis's considerable talents, dedication to the cause, and real military knowledge benefited the Confederacy, even if errors in judgment and failures of temperament detracted from those contributions. He established a strong relationship with his most talented general, Robert E. Lee, and recognized the need to concentrate military power in viable field armies rather than try to defend every square mile of Confederate territory. He extended central authority to mobilize the South's limited economic resources, including such controversial measures as conscription and the commandeering of supplies.

Davis realized that international aid would come only after decisive signs of Confederate success, and that the South could not rely on Britain and France to win its independence. He even proved willing to sacrifice slavery for the Southern cause, supporting Lee's proposal in 1864 to enroll slaves—with the promise of freedom—to serve in the depleted Confederate armies. While Lincoln had the political savvy to hold together a fractious domestic political environment in the North, Davis's cold, imperious manner and inability to rally public opinion hurt the South's war effort.